

Ambiguity Court Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-35 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	ambiguity-court

Big idea: Ambiguity is not just confusion; it reveals how context and assumptions complete meaning.

Overview

Students put ambiguous statements on trial and decide which interpretations are reasonable, strained, or unsupported.

Student Prompt

Inspect Ambiguity Court Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Ambiguity Court Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Sentence: 'I saw her duck.' Context A: a birdwatching trip. Context B: a football flying across the room. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Ambiguity Court Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Sentence: 'The teacher said the student was brilliant with a smile.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Ambiguity Court Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Sentence: 'The teacher said the student was brilliant with a smile.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Ambiguity is not just confusion; it reveals how context and assumptions complete meaning.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Ambiguity Court Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Ambiguity Court Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	How much meaning is in words and how much is in context?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how ambiguity is not just confusion; it reveals how context and assumptions complete meaning.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Choose sentences that are genuinely ambiguous but not socially risky.
- Add context gradually so students can see interpretation change in stages.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Sentence: 'I saw her duck.' Context A: a birdwatching trip. Context B: a football flying across the room.
- Sentence: 'The teacher said the student was brilliant with a smile.'

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Give groups an ambiguous sentence with no context.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Students list as many possible meanings as they can.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Add context cards one at a time and ask which meanings become stronger or weaker.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Groups defend one interpretation and challenge another.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief how context, intention, and audience shape linguistic knowledge.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Possible does not mean equally justified.
- What evidence moved an interpretation from possible to reasonable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may say language merely expresses thought rather than shaping interpretation.
- Students may identify bias in extreme examples but miss subtle framing.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Explains how wording changes interpretation before evidence is judged.
- Uses concrete language choices as evidence for a TOK claim.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: start with visual puns or simple ambiguous sentences.
- Challenge: distinguish semantic ambiguity, syntactic ambiguity, and pragmatic ambiguity.

Extension Tasks

- Students find ambiguity in a headline, policy, poem, or translated phrase.
- Connect ambiguity to legal interpretation or literary criticism.

Related Activities

- Definition Drift Debate
- Loaded Headline Laboratory
- Translation Loss Game